



Write to the Editor

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Digit will publish the best letters on these pages. Letters may be edited for clarity.

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are necessitated because twisted minds decided to pollute the Internet.

As for kicking pirates, we are with you, and hence the articles to educate our readers about the various aspects of piracy. We will also include this in future articles about the issue.

Digit, with every issue, also publishes a CD and DVD that carries PDFs from the previous month and earlier. The CD has PDFs for the last three months, while the DVD has PDFs for the last one year. We will be restarting this with effect from July 2005. The last CD/DVD to carry this was with the February 2005 issue.

What Is Anti-Virus Good For?

I am not an expert in computers. But when I buy something, I understand it and use it. As far as anti-virus is concerned, though, I am totally confused. I had Norton AntiVirus installed on my computer with Windows XP (without Service Pack 2) and used to update it regularly all these years.

Hence, I was under the impression that my computer was secure until one fine morning, to my greatest dismay, a window announced that my computer was infected by the 'Bloodhound' virus, and that Norton AntiVirus couldn't control it! This point forth, the computer started working on its own, pasting different words whenever I typed until eventually, I had to re-install Windows to solve the problem.

What do virus definitions mean? With anti-virus definitions being updated, I am under the impression that my computer is protected. But 'Bloodhound' is an old bandicoot and I am surprised that Norton was not able to stop it. So what is the purpose of the anti-viruses?

Is it only to create awareness that there are 'so many viruses' being introduced, or are anti-virus software actually capable of protecting computers from attacks?

C V Padmanabhan
Via E-mail

Dear Padmanabhan,
You may not be a computer expert, but you have hit the nail on the head! It's true, most of us do expect anti-virus software to be impenetrable, and are shocked when we realise that they are just as fallible as any other software. After all, whether it's a virus, an OS or anti-virus software, it's all code, written by imperfect humans.

In your case, you were probably hit by an 'updated' version of the Bloodhound virus, which was rebuilt to bypass Norton's security. Most malicious software writers seldom write code from scratch; instead, they rewrite or

'improve' the virus code, so as to bypass the majority of anti-virus programs.

Virus definitions are nothing but instructions given to anti-virus software about how to detect and remove known viruses. They don't always work, and most anti-virus software need you to also keep the software engine that detects and removes the viruses updated—not just the definitions. Another drawback is the OS, which may have security holes and allow malicious code to pass.

Nothing is 'safe' in the computing world and anti-virus software are just helmets that we wear as riders on the information highway. Accidents will happen. Be as cautious and prepared as possible!

Corrigendum

In the story titled *Pixel Palette* on page 61 of the April 2005 issue, Sanjay Kothari's name was misspelled. The URL, too, was wrong—it's actually www.sanjaykothari.com. We apologise for the error.

Editor's Note On The April 2005 DVD

Dear Reader,

A large percentage of the DVDs that accompanied the April 2005 issue of *Digit* were non-functional. *Digit* has already sent letters to all its subscribers with valid e-mail IDs apologising for the same. All subscribers will find the April replacement DVD along with the May 2005 issue.

A section of *Digit's* newsstand readers also complained of non-working DVDs. Since we are unable to reach out to each and every individual newsstand buyer, we would request all readers who bought the April 2005 issue of *Digit* from their local newsstand to send an e-mail to dvd@thinkdigit.com along with their name, complete address, telephone number with STD code, and the *Digit* Patron code printed on the last page of the issue.

Once we receive a request from newsstand readers for a replacement DVD along with all the valid details, *Digit* will ensure that it will send a fully-functional replacement DVD free of cost anywhere in India.

We once again apologise for the inconvenience caused, with the express promise that we will never let this happen again.

We would also like to thank our esteemed readers for bearing with us.

Sachin Kalbag
Executive Editor
Digit

Seeing The Alternative Is The Future

I purchased the *Digit* April 2005 edition from a newsstand, since I was particularly keen to get my hands on OpenOffice.org 2 Beta. I had hoped that your distribution would include both Windows and Linux versions.

I was disappointed to find that you had included only the former. Have you included the Linux version previously, or will I have to buy your magazine again next month to get it?

The abovementioned problem, though, was the least of my worries, as I found out that apart from 'OoO2b', nothing else could be copied from either the CD or the DVD. Even the wallpapers could not be opened! This double-whammy makes me wonder if this was just a once-in-a-while error or whether it was a whole batch that went bad.

I am returning both the CD and the DVD for replacement, with the hope that you'll send me working copies at the earliest. I can't wait to try some of the other software they contain, including Bitdefender.

I have a suggestion: I do not see any point in replicating the software already on the DVD onto the CD. People with DVD drives are anyway able to use CDs. Why don't you put the most popular or important or essential software on the CD, and leave the free space on the DVD for other things, such as source code?

Which brings me on to the next topic: despite distributing various flavours of GNU/Linux, I believe you are not doing enough. I think much more can be done. For example, you can package Windows and Linux binaries, along with source code for excellent software such as VLC.

There will be many geeks who might want to tweak things around. With the space savings from the CD, you can also include cross compilers such as MinGW (under Essentials) so that Windows fans, too, can enjoy the best of both worlds.

Nishit Dave, Pune
Via e-mail

LETTER
OF THE
MONTH